Once upon a time, on an island called Mledina in a far-off Eastern sea, there lived a people with strange customs and taboos. Each June, on the longest day of the year, all the Mledina men journeyed in a huge sailing vessel to a distant, sacred island called Serona, there to commune with an enormous toad. All night long the toad would enchant them with marvelous tales of stars and galaxies, pulsars and quasars. The next day the men would sail back to Mledina, filled with inspiration that sustained them for the whole of the following year.

Each December, on the longest night of the year, the Mledina women sailed to Serona, communed with the same toad all the next day, and returned the next night, inspired with the toad's visions of stars and galaxies, quasars and pulsars.

Now, it was absolutely taboo for any Mledina woman to describe to any Mledina man her journey to the sacred island of Serona, or any details of the toad's tales. The Mledina men were ruled by the same taboo. Never must they expose to a woman anything about their annual voyage.

In the summer of 1905 a radical Mledina youth named Albert, who cared little for the taboos of his culture, discovered and exposed to all the Mledinans, female and male, two sacred maps. One was the map by which the Mledina priestess guided the sailing vessel on the women's midwinter journey. The other was the map used by the Mledina priest on the men's midsummer voyage. What shame the men felt, having their sacred map exposed. The women's shame was no less. But there the maps were, for everyone to see—and they contained a great shock: They disagreed about the location of Serona. The women were sailing eastward 210 furlongs, then northward 100 furlongs, while the men were sailing eastward 164.5 furlongs, then northward 164.5 furlongs. How could this be? Religious tradition was firm; the women and the men were to seek their annual inspiration from the same sacred toad on the same sacred island of Serona.

Most of the Mledinans dealt with their shame by pretending the exposed maps were fakes. But a wise old Mledina man named Hermann believed. For three years he struggled to understand the mystery of the maps' discrepancy. Finally, one autumn day in 1908, the truth came to him: The Mledina men must be navigating by magnetic compass, and the Mledina women by the stars (Figure 2.1). The Mledina men reckoned north and east magnetically, the Mledina women reckoned them by the rotation of the